

ART BEYOND AGE: WORKSHOPS & CURRICULUM

Our workshops are designed to bridge the gap between clinical wellness and creative expression. Every element, from the brush handle to the emotional arc of the session, is curated for the specific needs of older adults.

1. The 12-Week Foundation Curriculum

The program is structured as three 4-week arcs, each building on the last. By Week 12, every participant has a portfolio of 12 artworks and a transformed relationship with their creativity.

Weeks 1–4: Safety & Play	Establish the psychological safety contract. Remove fear of failure and build group trust. Introduce color, mark-making, and texture without technical vocabulary. Outcome: Participants leave each session surprised by their own creations.
Weeks 5–8: Skill & Meaning	Introduce specific techniques (botanical, mandala, portrait, collage) paired with life-narrative themes. Skill develops alongside self-reflection. Outcome: Development of an artistic vocabulary and a deeper understanding of personal story.
Weeks 9–12: Legacy & Celebration	The final arc turns inward, then outward. Includes illustrated letters and collaborative canvases. The free-choice session affirms autonomy. Outcome: A final exhibition where families witness the transformation and participants are honored publicly.

2. Art Techniques

Techniques are chosen for their therapeutic and accessibility properties, specifically suited for the bodies and minds of seniors.

Watercolor Wash

The flow of water and pigment is pleasurable and forgiving. It rewards spontaneity and penalizes rigidity, facilitating the psychological shift seniors need. Deeply calming sensory experience.

Mandala Drawing

Repetitive, meditative geometry clinically shown to reduce anxiety. Provides cognitive scaffolding for those with early memory concerns and resonates culturally with Indian seniors.

Botanical Painting

Connects to deep cultural memories of nature and gardening. Observation of living things promotes mindfulness. The subject matter is inherently forgiving—nature has no "wrong" shapes.

Collage and Mixed Media

Inclusive and requiring no drawing skill. The act of choosing and placing images is inherently narrative, allowing participants to create visual autobiographies (Life-Review).

Hand & Block Printing

Removes "drawing anxiety." Exercises fine motor coordination through the physical sensation of pressing and lifting. Produces repeatable, beautiful results that build confidence.

Acrylic on Canvas

Creates a "trophy-worthy" physical artifact. Validating to hold a stretched canvas. The opacity allows mistakes to be painted over, removing permanent mistake anxiety.

3. Adaptations: The Accessibility Framework

Creative Aging is not a "watered-down" art class. It is art designed from the ground up for older adults. These adaptations ensure credibility with healthcare professionals.

For Arthritis & Limited Grip

- Wider, foam-handled brushes requiring minimal pressure.
- Sponge application instead of brushes for "dab and press" movements.
- 5-minute hand warm-ups and stretches before sessions.
- Tearing paper (collage) to replace scissor work.
- Techniques that welcome imprecision (wash, print, stamp).

For Tremor & Parkinson's

- Watercolour wet-on-wet: water absorbs tremor into natural texture.
- Large-scale work (A3+) providing a larger target area.
- Weighted brushes to dampen involuntary movement.
- Stabilized canvases using non-slip mats or binder clips.
- Framing tremor-marks as intentional "energy" and texture.

For Early Memory Concerns

- Consistent session structure to reduce cognitive load.
- One instruction at a time: demonstrate, invite, then observe.
- Multi-sensory prompts (music, scent) to activate memory.
- Portfolio review at the start of each session to reinforce progress.
- Familiar subjects (flowers, faces) to activate long-term memory.

For Vision Impairment

- High-contrast materials (black on white, vivid colors).
- Tactile techniques (clay, textured collage) using touch as the primary sense.
- Bold outlines printed or embossed for tracing confidence.
- Optimal lighting and verbal descriptions during the sharing circle.

The Facilitator's Core Stance

Adaptations are framed as **creative techniques**, not accommodations. A participant with a tremor isn't doing a "different version"; they are using "organic texture techniques." This preserves dignity and ensures full participation.

4. Workshop Gallery

[Collage of Workshop 1 Pictures]

[Collage of Workshop 2 Pictures]

[Collage of Workshop 3 Pictures]